

A FIELD GUIDE TO

Imaginary Birds

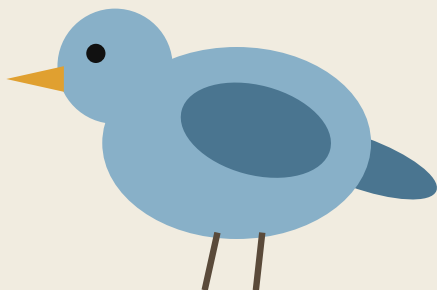
Twelve species you will never see



How to Use This Guide

Every bird in this book has been observed by at least one person who was not quite paying attention. Each entry lists where the bird is said to live, what it is said to sound like, and the best time to fail to see it.

Readers are encouraged to keep their own notes in the margins. Sightings cannot be confirmed, but they can be enjoyed.



No. 01

Teacup Warbler

HABITAT

Kitchen windowsills, early morning.

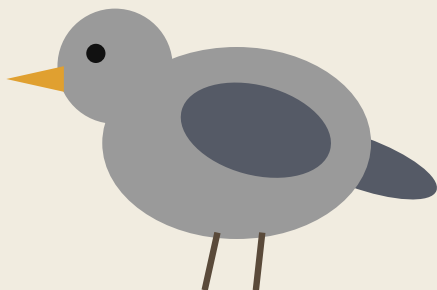
CALL

A soft clink, like a spoon set down.

FIELD NOTES

Only sings when the kettle is about to boil.

My sightings:



No. 02

Lesser Umbrella Heron

HABITAT

Bus stops during light drizzle.

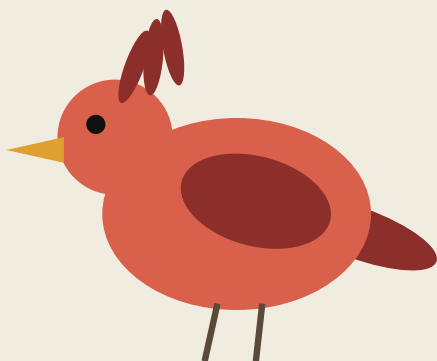
CALL

A papery flap.

FIELD NOTES

Stands on one leg and pretends to be closed.

My sightings:



No. 03

Crested Daydream

HABITAT

The last row of any classroom.

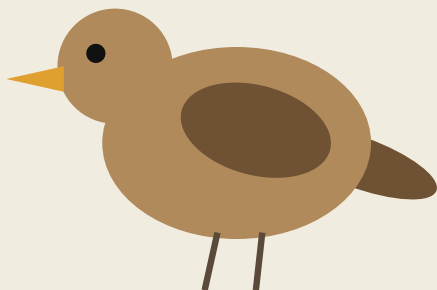
CALL

A long, unfinished hum.

FIELD NOTES

Vanishes the moment it is named aloud.

My sightings:



No. 04

Library Owl

HABITAT

Between the shelves of unread books.

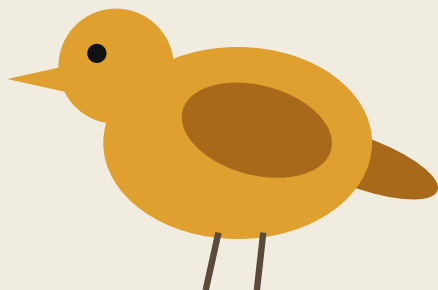
CALL

A disapproving “hush”.

FIELD NOTES

Nests in returned books with bent corners.

My sightings:



No. 05

Copper Lantern Finch

HABITAT

Harbours at dusk.

CALL

A low, warm whistle.

FIELD NOTES

Its feathers are said to glow when someone is late home.

My sightings:



No. 06

Paper Swift

HABITAT

Above desks near open windows.

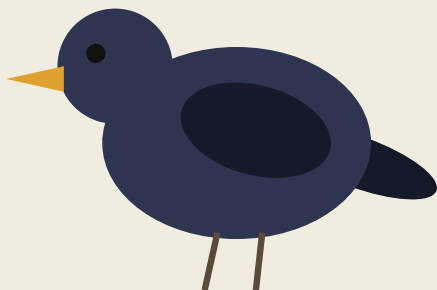
CALL

The rustle of a page turning.

FIELD NOTES

Migrates every time a letter is sent.

My sightings:



No. 07

Midnight Plover

HABITAT

Empty beaches under a new moon.

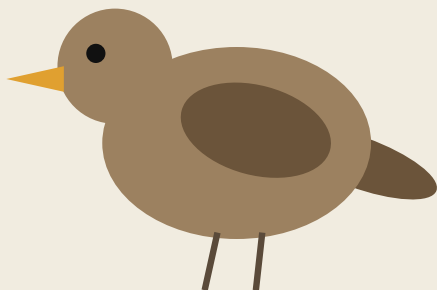
CALL

Two notes, then a long pause.

FIELD NOTES

Visible only out of the corner of the eye.

My sightings:



No. 08

Common Somewhere Sparrow

HABITAT

Everywhere you are not.

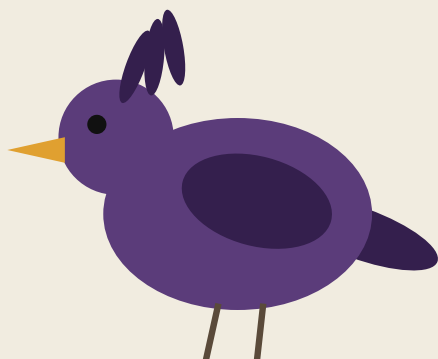
CALL

A cheerful, distant chirp.

FIELD NOTES

The most widespread imaginary bird.

My sightings:



No. 09

Velvet Thunderbird

HABITAT

Hilltops before a storm.

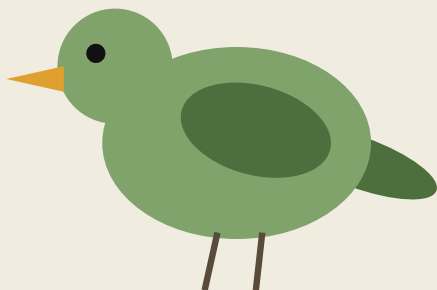
CALL

A rumble felt in the chest.

FIELD NOTES

Children report it more often than adults.

My sightings:



No. 10

Garden Muddle

HABITAT

Under hedges, near lost gloves.

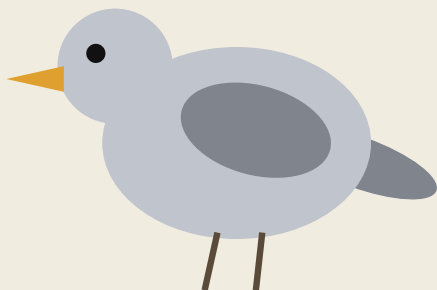
CALL

A confused, three-note question.

FIELD NOTES

Often found sitting on the thing you are looking for.

My sightings:



No. 11

Silver-Tongued Rumourbird

HABITAT

Markets, staircases, doorways.

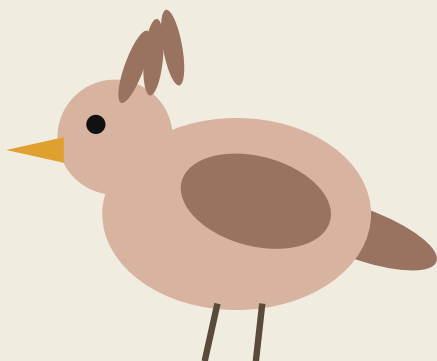
CALL

A whisper that changes each time.

FIELD NOTES

No two reports agree, which proves its existence.

My sightings:



No. 12

Quiet Hour Wren

HABITAT

Wherever someone is reading.

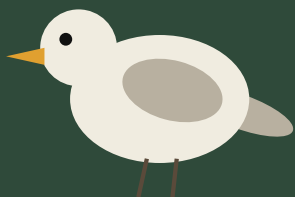
CALL

None. It is the silence itself.

FIELD NOTES

You are probably near one now.

My sightings:



Keep looking up.